

Hyperbole and Understatement as Alternative Politeness Strategies

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Today's plan

1. Hyperbole and understatement
2. Politeness Theory
3. Praise
4. Experimental Component

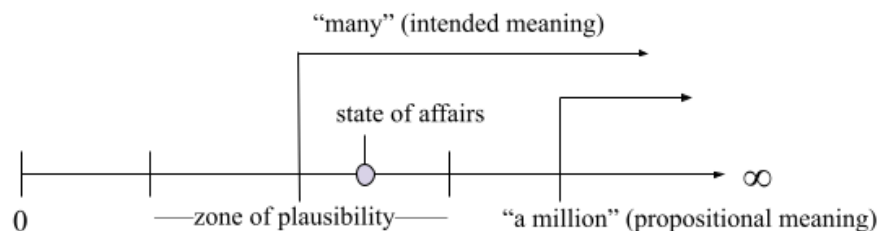
Conceptual space: Hyperbole

Hyperbole involves extreme scalar displacement

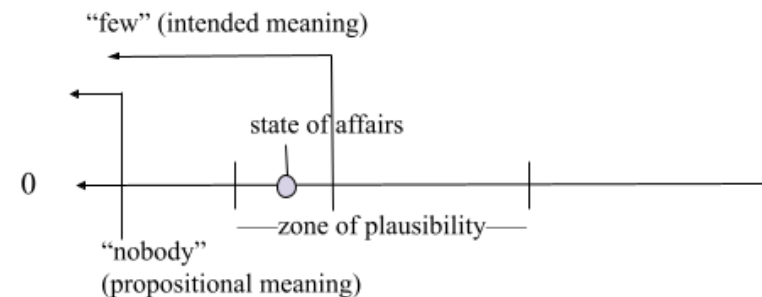
- Upscaling: (1) ‘There were a million people in your living room.’
- Downscaling: (2) ‘No one came yesterday.’

Hyperbole can operate through extreme amplification or reduction
Importantly: both propositions are literally false.

Hyperbole (upscaling)



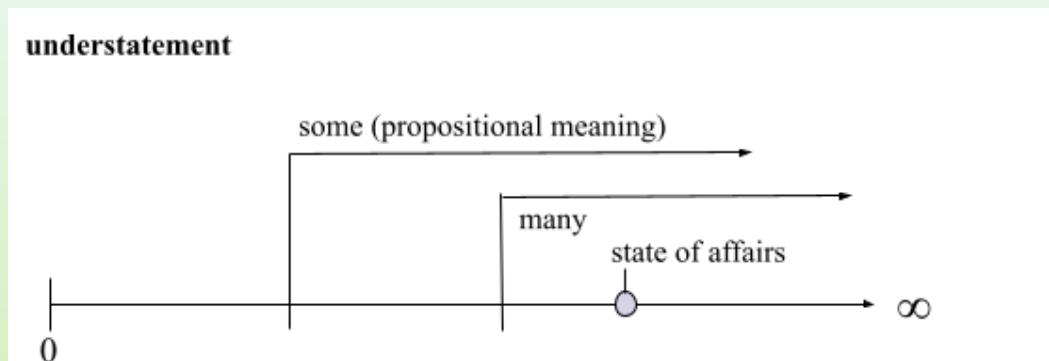
Hyperbole (downscaling)



Conceptual space: Understatement

Understatement involves scalar weakening

- (3) ‘Some people came to the party.’



Importantly: the proposition remains literally true, used to downplay or minimise the state of affairs

- (4) ‘I had a little mishap and I can’t make it to the office today.’

Social motivation: Politeness

Semantic contrast

- Hyperbole: extreme scale, **literal falsity**, stronger intended meaning
- Understatement: mid-scale, **literal truth**, weaker wording
- Different truth profiles → different pragmatic affordances

Politeness theory

- Brown & Levinson (1987)
 - Face: public self-image individuals seek to maintain
 - Politeness strategies: to avoid or minimise potential face loss
 - Several speech acts are face-threatening acts (FTAs), such as requests, criticism or **evaluations**.
 - On record vs off-record strategies
- Direct vs indirect expression → with off-record strategies, speakers are able to retract
- Understatement and hyperbole are classified as off-record strategies

Sociological variables

- Weight of face-threatening act: $W_x = P(H, S) + D(S, H) + R_x$
 - P = Power relation
 - D = Social distance
 - R = Ranking of imposition
- Higher weight → greater use of politeness strategies

Power in interaction

- Power often treated as stable hierarchy

This experimental design simplifies power as role-based hierarchy

However,

- Interactional research (Bousfield & Locher, 2008): power is dynamic and negotiable
- Lower-status speakers can exercise interactional power

Lower-status speakers addressing hearers in *tutoyer* instead of *vouvoyer*

Why look at praise?

- Motivated by contrast with Gotzner & Mazzarella's work (2021) on negative evaluation and politeness argument for polarity asymmetries
- **How is praise face-threatening?**
- **What is the apt way to praise?**
- Aptness of hyperbole vs understatement as politeness strategies is not experimentally tested

Pilot Experiment 1

- 2×3 between-subjects design, each participant only sees one condition
- Factors: Power & Utterance Type
- Experiment 2: manipulation of Social Distance while keeping Power and Rank of imposition constant

Materials

Jim has recently started working as an editing intern in a publishing house. During lunch he is discussing with Paul, **a fellow intern who also started working there recently / his manager who has been in the company for 5 years**. Paul makes reference to a widely known book on the topic and expresses surprise that Jim hasn't read it. Paul recommends it strongly.

Jim follows his **co-worker's/manager's** recommendation and reads the book. You know that **he really liked the book**.

During another lunch break some weeks later, Jim says to Paul:

“By the way, thank you for the book recommendation, it was rather good / really good / the best book I have ever read!”

Measures

- Politeness: *How polite was the speaker?*
- Warmth: *How warm was the speaker?*
- Sincerity: *How sincere was the speaker?*
- Inferred positivity of opinion: *How positive do you think the speaker's opinion of the book was?*

7-point scales:

Not at all polite	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	Extremely polite
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Hypothesis for hyperbole

Hyperbole

- *Peer context*: interlocutors prioritise expression of affective state, central to hyperbole, and solidarity, over describing precisely the ensuing event (**literally falsity backgrounded**)
→ hyperbole is perceived as playful and affiliative, signals enthusiasm
- *Hierarchical context*: interlocutors avoid being perceived as flattering or insincere (**literal falsity foregrounded**)

Hypothesis for understatement

Understatement

- *Peer context*: unnecessarily reserved/cold
- *Hierarchical context*: reserved, precise description of events
Speaker signals self-reservation, non-chalance

Horn (1989) mentions that in Western cultures there is sometimes a taboo to state positive emotions directly and to show excessive enthusiasm. Because of this, speakers may use a weaker statement in order to safeguard their face, especially when talking to someone higher in social hierarchy, in order not to appear overly positive.

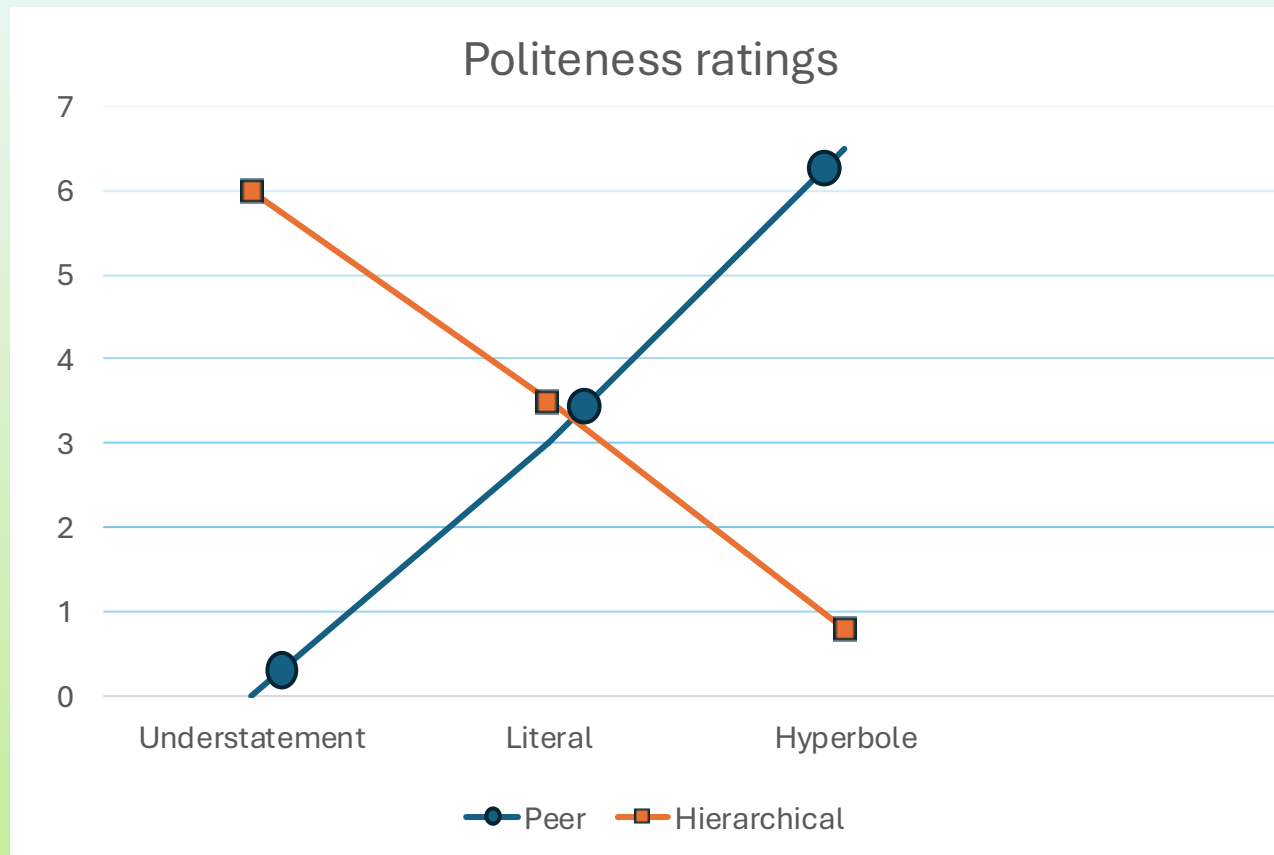
Predictions

- Politeness rating:
hierarchical context $\rightarrow$ understatement $>$ literal $>$ hyperbole
peer context $\rightarrow$ hyperbole $>$ literal $>$ understatement
- Warmth rating: hyperbole highest regardless of context
- Sincerity rating: hyperbole perceived less sincere in hierarchical than peer context

Predictions for politeness rating

Extremely polite

Not at all polite



Thank you for your attention!

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"I can give you hyperbole, some spin, a little rhetoric,
but, no, no comment."

References

Bousfield, D., & Locher, M. A. (Eds.). (2008). *Impoliteness in language: Studies on its interplay with power in theory and practice* (Vol. 21). Walter de Gruyter.

Brown, P., & Levinson, S. C. (1987). *Politeness: Some universals in language usage* (Vol. 4). Cambridge university press.

Gotzner, N., & Mazzarella, D. (2021). Face management and negative strengthening: The role of power relations, social distance, and gender. *Frontiers in psychology*, 12, 602977.

Horn, L. R. (1989). A natural history of negation.